THE DUDELA CO.

The Dudela Prep Kit

Your no nonsense guide to showing up strong.



Prepare together.

REAL DADS. USEFUL PLANS.

Six pillars. Nine practical tools. Real stories from our families to yours.

John & Mike | The Dudela Co.

WELCOME

You do not have to know everything.

You do need somewhere honest to start.

Hey. We're John and Mike. Two dads, a lot of strong opinions, and absolutely no interest in handing you another parenting manual that makes you feel behind before you've started.

Maybe you're excited. Maybe you're quietly terrified. Maybe you've spent an hour comparing strollers because it feels easier than admitting you're worried about the birth. You can want this baby more than anything and still wonder what you've signed up for.

We have been there

For John and Viv, it was a complicated twin pregnancy and a month in the NICU. For Mike and Abigail, it was a birth plan that changed in about ninety seconds. Neither family got to prepare for every possibility. Both families had to learn how to move through it together.

This is a family conversation

You'll hear from us as dads, see our actual families, and find Abigail's Corner alongside the practical work. Abigail, Mike's wife, brings her perspective as a licensed, Board Certified Behavior Analyst. Viv's perspective brings us back to a home that can be lived in, loved in, and a little chaotic.

> **What we want for you**
>
> Finish with a plan you and your partner recognize as yours: who owns what, what matters during birth, where to get help, and how you'll handle those first days home.

Use these pages together. Argue kindly about what matters. Cross out what doesn't fit. This is your family, not an exam.

START HERE

Your first useful hour.

You can make progress without finishing the whole book today.

First 10 minutes · Find the gaps

Fill out the Readiness Map on the next page. Choose one thing that is unclear and one action you can take today. If the birth is close, start with hospital logistics and the first days home.

Next 20 minutes · Make room for two perspectives

Ask your partner when she has the energy for a short planning conversation. Bring a draft of what you can own. Use the Partner Conversation on page 15. Listen before changing the plan.

Next 20 minutes · Build the working plan

Complete the Birth Support Brief, Hospital Logistics, and First 72 Hours tools together. Leave anything medical for your care team to answer. Put unanswered questions on the page rather than guessing.

Last 10 minutes · Assign the next actions

Name the owner, the deadline, and the backup for the three most important open items. Put one check in on your calendar for next week.

> **Your minimum useful result**
>
> Today, know who to call, how you will get to the birth location, what your partner wants you to handle, and who can help once you get home.

The six pillars

Get Your Head Right • Get Your Money Ready • Be The Partner She Needs • Know What You're Walking Into • Decide What Kind of Dad You Want to Be • First Days Home Playbook

TOOL 01 OF 09

The Readiness Map

Circle one status in each row. Unclear is a useful answer.

AREA	STATUS	NEXT ACTION
My stress and support	Ready / Working / Unclear	
Leave and money	Ready / Working / Unclear	
Household ownership	Ready / Working / Unclear	
Birth preferences and contacts	Ready / Working / Unclear	
The dad I want to be	Ready / Working / Unclear	
First days home	Ready / Working / Unclear	

The one uncertainty weighing on me most

The action I can take today

OUR NEXT THREE ACTIONS	OWNER	BY WHEN

We will review this plan together on

DONE MEANS

Each of your three actions has a named owner and a deadline. You have a time to return to the unfinished questions.

PILLAR 01

Get Your Head Right

Stay present without pretending you are fine.

You're having a baby. Your partner is growing a person. The calendar keeps moving. Somewhere in there, someone asks whether you're excited and you say, "Yeah, absolutely," because explaining the other six feelings would take a while.

You can be happy and scared. Grateful and grieving the freedom you're about to lose. Ready to meet your baby and nowhere near ready to feel responsible for everything. Those feelings don't cancel each other out.

Notice it before it runs the room

Maybe you get quiet. Maybe every small question sounds like criticism. Maybe you keep finding one more thing to do at work. Start by saying what's underneath it: "I'm scared about money." "I don't know what I'll do if the birth gets complicated." Naming it gives you something to work with.

Practice a small reset

When it's safe, pause. Put your feet down. Slow your breathing. Name the feeling. Choose the next useful action. You're practicing how to come back, not trying to eliminate every uncomfortable feeling.

> **Something you can actually say**
>
> "I'm getting overwhelmed and I don't want to take it out on you. I need five minutes. Then I'm coming back and I'll handle dinner." Make sure the pause is safe, give a return time, and come back.

Make it yours

Fill out the Calm and Support Card. Choose someone besides your partner you can call honestly. She can love you and still need you to have support that isn't all on her.

JOHN'S STORY

The parking garage counts too.

John | From our original kit



I'd hold it together upstairs, get to the parking garage, and break for a few minutes. Then I'd go back up.

Viv had a complicated twin pregnancy. Our girls shared a placenta. There was a cerclage at 20 weeks, concerns about their growth, and more trips to the hospital than I can count. Lolli and Genevieve arrived at 34 weeks and went straight to the NICU for a month.

I remember trying to be calm for Viv while quietly coming apart inside. I'd hold it together upstairs, get to the parking garage, and break for a few minutes. Then I'd go back up.

I'm telling you that because "showing up strong" can sound like never needing anything. That wasn't my experience. I needed room to feel what was happening too.

> **Take this into your own plan**
>
> Where can you be honest? Who can take your call? Write that person down before you need them. You do not have to wait until you're falling apart to deserve support.

ABIGAIL'S CORNER

Practice before the pressure.

Abigail Colander | Mike's wife | Licensed, Board Certified Behavior Analyst

I'm Abigail, Mike's wife. Around here he's Michael. By day I'm a licensed, Board Certified Behavior Analyst, which means I think about behavior for a living. At home I'm married to the steadiest man I know, and I got to watch that steadiness work when it counted.

When our birth plan turned into an emergency C section, the room moved fast. Michael didn't freeze and he didn't take over. He asked the questions that needed answers. Where are Abigail and Riley going to be? Who do I talk to next? What happens now? I didn't have the energy to ask any of it. He did.

Here's the part I want you to hear: that wasn't luck, and it wasn't just his personality. Staying steady under pressure is a skill. Skills get stronger with practice, and the best time to practice is long before a delivery room.

Try it in a small moment

When you feel rushed or irritated this week, notice what's happening in your body. Name the feeling without judging yourself. If it's safe, pause before you answer. Then choose one useful action, even if it's just one good question. Small and repeatable beats perfectly calm.

> **Talk about it together**
>
> Ask your partner: "When I'm stressed, what do you notice first?" Listen to the answer. It may be different from the story you tell yourself.

TOOL 02 OF 09

Your Calm and Support Card

A short plan for the moment you notice yourself getting overloaded.

My early warning signs are

The feeling I often have trouble naming is

My reset

Notice the signal. Pause if safe. Put both feet down. Slow my breathing. Name the feeling. Choose one useful action.

My words when I need a pause and my return time

One action that helps me return ready to participate

PERSON OR PROFESSIONAL	HOW TO REACH THEM	WHAT I CAN ASK FOR

If this keeps happening, my next support step is

DONE MEANS

You have one realistic reset and one person you can actually contact. Your partner knows what a pause means and when you will return.

PILLAR 02

Get Your Money Ready

Replace the vague worry with your household's actual numbers.

Money has a way of entering a conversation that appeared to be about something else. The stroller. The takeout. Whether one more delivery box really needed to arrive today. Sometimes the thing underneath is, "I have no idea what our income will look like when the baby gets here."

Start with the numbers you actually have

Open the accounts. Look at expected take home pay during leave. Write down the essential bills, then add your best estimates for baby costs. You can label a number as an estimate. You cannot plan around a number you both assume the other person knows.

Ask the boring questions now

Confirm leave dates, eligibility, pay, and deadlines with the relevant employer or benefits administrator. Ask your insurer about coverage changes and enrollment timing. If you work for yourself, decide what can pause and what needs a backup.

Separate a purchase from a priority

You may need transport, feeding supplies, childcare, or a way to cover time away from work. You do not need every product recommended by a person with a ring light. Agree on what matters to your household before shopping becomes the planning process.

> **Keep the conversation kind**
>
> If the numbers are tight, say so. Pick the next decision together. A cash gap is something to plan for; it does not tell you whether you're going to be a good dad.

Use the Leave and Money Plan. Confirm financial, legal, insurance, and benefit decisions with the appropriate provider or adviser.

MIKE'S STORY

Have the conversation before week 38.

Mike | From our original kit

We waited too long to have the money conversation. By the time we sat down in week 38, we were both exhausted and anxious. The numbers hadn't become easier because we'd avoided them.

Twenty minutes with a spreadsheet in week 30 would have been a much better use of our energy than trying to work it out when we were already worn down.

That's why this section asks you to sit down together. The point is to see the same picture while you still have room to make a few decisions.

> **Your conversation starter**
>
> "Can we look at what's coming in during leave and what we need to cover? I want us both to know the plan." Bring the numbers you can find. Share the job of confirming the rest.

TOOL 03 OF 09

The Leave and Money Plan

Use one consistent period for the totals below, such as one month during leave.

LEAVE	PARENT ONE	PARENT TWO
Leave dates and paid / unpaid weeks		
Expected take home pay		
Confirmed with / on		

HOUSEHOLD CASH FLOW	AMOUNT
Expected income during this period	
Existing essential spending	
Added baby and childcare spending	
Total expected spending	
Income less total spending	
One time costs to plan separately	

If there is a gap, our next decision is

UNKNOWN OR DEADLINE	WHO WILL CONFIRM IT	BY WHEN
Most urgent question or deadline		

DONE MEANS

Both of you can explain the expected gap or surplus, the assumptions behind it, and the next action. These are planning estimates, not promised costs or financial advice.

PILLAR 03

Be The Partner She Needs

Take ownership of the work, including the thinking.

“Just tell me what to do” sounds helpful until you realize it makes your partner the project manager of your participation. She still has to notice the thing, explain the thing, and remember whether the thing happened.

Own the whole thing

Take dinner. Check what’s in the fridge, figure out the meal, get what’s missing, cook, and deal with the dishes. If every step requires another question, the responsibility hasn’t really moved.

Ask about the parts that matter

Ownership doesn’t mean guessing what your partner wants for her body, her recovery, or her birth. Ask. Learn her preferences. Agree on what the result should look like, then handle the practical work you’ve taken on.

You are both allowed to be human

You’ll get tired. You’ll misunderstand each other. The useful move is to notice the miss and repair it: “I said I’d do that. I didn’t, and it landed back on you. Here’s what I’m doing now.” Follow it with action.

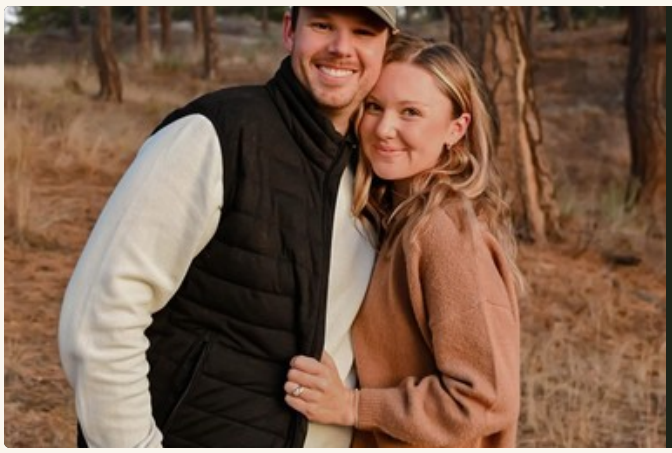
> **Have this conversation before you need it**
>
> “When we’re both exhausted, how do we tell each other we need help? What can we simplify? Who can we call?” A plan made while you like each other is useful when the night gets long.

Use the Ownership Plan and Partner Conversation together. Start with responsibilities you can own reliably. Review them when recovery, feeding, or work changes the picture.

ABIGAIL'S CORNER

Make the helpful thing easier.

Abigail Colander | Mike's wife | Licensed, Board Certified Behavior Analyst



Not "helped with." Owned.

"Be more helpful" leaves a lot to interpret. "Check the changing supplies each evening and restock what we need" gives you an action, a time, and a way to know it happened.

When we brought Riley home, Michael owned the bottles and the cleaning. Not "helped with." Owned. While I fed Riley and recovered, that whole part of the house was simply handled. It's one of my favorite memories of those weeks, and honestly it's mostly about dish soap.

That's what ownership looks like in real life. It isn't a grand gesture. It's one clear job, done the whole way through, so the other person can stop carrying it in her head. Before Riley was born, we talked about wanting a home where we actually talk to each other. A clear conversation about who owns the bottles, or the laundry, is a very practical place to start.

> **Try it together**
>
> Choose one recurring job. Name the owner, what starts the routine, and what done looks like. After a few days, ask whether the arrangement reduced the load for both of you.

TOOL 04 OF 09

The Ownership Plan

The owner handles noticing, planning, doing, and following through.

RESPONSIBILITY	OWNER	WHAT DONE MEANS	BACKUP
Meals and groceries			
Laundry and cleaning			
Hospital preparation			
Visitors and family updates			
Appointments and paperwork			
Other			

One responsibility I will take over fully this week

What I need to clarify before I begin

What we can simplify or stop for now

Our next review date

DONE MEANS

You both know who owns each priority. The owner knows the result and the backup. The list reduces reminders rather than creating another thing for your partner to manage.

TOOL 05 OF 09

The Partner Conversation

Set aside 20 minutes when you both have enough energy. Ask, listen, then make one decision.

What feels heaviest for you right now?

What am I doing that helps? What should I change?

What are we each worried about but not saying?

What do we want around visitors, privacy, and family updates?

When we are both tired, how will we ask for help or repair an argument?

ONE DECISION WE MADE	WHO OWNS THE NEXT STEP	WHEN

DONE MEANS

Each person has been heard. You have one concrete decision and a time to revisit anything unresolved. You do not need to settle every relationship question in one sitting.

PILLAR 04

Know What You're Walking Into

Know your role, your care team, and how to get help.

There is a particular kind of helplessness that comes from standing in a room where everyone seems to understand what's happening except you. Preparation gives you a better place to stand.

Learn your job before the room gets busy

Take a childbirth class. Ask the care team about labor, delivery, recovery, and what your support role can look like. Save the right phone numbers. Know where you're going and which entrance is open after hours. These small details matter when your attention is elsewhere.

Keep her voice in the room

Talk about preferences before birth. Does she want reassurance, touch, quiet, practical help? Ask again in the moment. Hold the information, help ask questions, and keep her wishes central. Being prepared does not mean deciding for her.

Ask a question you can understand

"What's happening?" "How urgent is this?" "What do you recommend and why?" "Is there time to ask about alternatives?" You don't need impressive terminology. You need to understand the answer. Never assume it is safe to delay urgent care.

> **Take the concern seriously**
>
> If your partner thinks something is wrong, help her get assessed. Do not talk her out of care because you think it is probably nothing. Save the urgent warning sign resource included near the end of this kit.

Complete the Birth Support Brief and Hospital Logistics together. Bring medical questions to your care team. A plan can guide you even when the day changes.

MIKE'S STORY

Ninety seconds. A different plan.

Mike | From our original kit



The plan we had prepared for was gone, but she still needed me there.

Abigail had thought through the birth plan. The music, the lighting, the way she wanted to move through labor. Then things shifted fast and the OB called for an emergency C section.

In about ninety seconds we went from one picture of the day to a completely different one. Abigail looked at me. The plan we had prepared for was gone, but she still needed me there.

That moment stayed with me. Know the plan. Know what matters to your partner. Then be ready to listen, adapt, and help with what is happening in front of you.

> **A question worth asking now**
>
> "If things change quickly, what would help you feel supported by me?" Let your partner answer in her own words. Write it into the Birth Support Brief.

TOOL 06 OF 09

The Birth Support Brief

Complete together. This supports a conversation with the care team; it is not consent or a medical order.

Birth location and care team

What matters most to my partner during birth

What she wants from me when she is uncomfortable or scared

Preferences we want to discuss with the care team

Questions about labor, procedures, recovery, or an unexpected change

Privacy and update preferences

If the plan changes, my practical responsibilities are

DONE MEANS

Your partner recognizes her preferences in this page. Medical questions are marked for the care team. You understand that preferences may change and that urgent care cannot always wait.

TOOL 07 OF 09

Hospital Logistics

Keep a copy on both phones. Store sensitive medical details securely.

WHO OR WHERE	PHONE / ADDRESS / INSTRUCTIONS
Care team daytime contact	
Care team after hours contact	
Birth location and correct entrance	
If we cannot reach the care team	
Transport and backup driver	
Home, pet, or older child support	

Confirm with your care team

When should we call or come in? Where do we go after hours? What should we do in an emergency? Save the local emergency number appropriate to where you live.

Pack and check

Confirm the birth location's guidance. Check identification and requested paperwork, medications and relevant information as instructed, chargers, comfortable clothing, toiletries, food where permitted, baby's going home items, and an appropriate car seat if traveling by car. Learn its use before the trip.

Items still to pack or confirm and who owns them

Route, parking, and backup transport checked on

DONE MEANS

You can reach the right team, find the entrance, arrange transport, and leave home without making the key decisions from scratch.

PILLAR 05

Decide What Kind of Dad You Want to Be

Turn the big intention into a behavior someone can see.

One day your kid will describe you to someone. You probably won't get to edit the description. What do you hope they say?

That question is more useful than trying to become a perfect dad. It gets you closer to the life you want to practice: showing up, listening, keeping a promise, and owning it when you get something wrong.

Keep the good. Change what needs changing.

Think about the adults who raised you. What made you feel safe or seen? What did you need and not get? You can appreciate your own dad and still choose to do something differently. You can break a pattern without pretending the work will be easy.

Put the value on the calendar

If presence matters, decide when the phone goes away. If partnership matters, own a routine. If honesty matters, practice saying "I got that wrong" without adding a defense at the end.

> **Choose a promise that survives a hard day**
>
> "I'll be patient forever" is asking a lot. "When I get short, I'll notice it, apologize, and come back to the conversation" gives you something to practice.

Use the Dad Commitments page. Share one commitment with your partner and ask whether it would make a difference she can actually feel.

FROM OUR FAMILIES

The kind of home you're building.

The family behind the framework



"In our house, we want it to be normal to..."

Before Riley was born, Mike and Abigail talked about the feeling they wanted their home to have. They wanted honesty. They wanted a family that actually talked. Simple words, but saying them out loud gave them something to come back to.

You can have that conversation before you know how to swaddle or which drawer the tiny socks belong in. What should it feel like to be a kid in your house? What should it feel like to be your partner?

You don't need a framed family manifesto. Choose one thing you want to make ordinary. Being listened to. Being able to admit a mistake. A dad who puts his phone down when he says he's paying attention.

> **Bring it into everyday life**
>
> Finish this together: "In our house, we want it to be normal to..." Then choose one small behavior that would make that sentence true.

TOOL 08 OF 09

Your Dad Commitments

Your child will experience your habits more often than your intentions.

One thing from my upbringing I want to carry forward

One pattern I want to change and the behavior I will practice instead

VALUE	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN OUR HOME
Presence	
Shared responsibility	
A value I choose	

My one daily commitment for the next two weeks

When I miss it, how I will repair and restart

The person I will ask to check in with me and when

DONE MEANS

Your commitment describes something you can do, not a standard of perfection. Your partner can tell you whether it makes a useful difference.

PILLAR 06

First Days Home Playbook

Build a rhythm that protects care, recovery, and rest.

Eventually you get home. The baby is there. The bags are there. Somehow there is already laundry. Everyone is hungry at a different time, and the word “routine” feels wildly optimistic.

Start with the basics: care, recovery, food, and opportunities to rest. You can build from there. A newborn does not need a household that looks ready for a photograph.

Bring the care plan home with you

Before discharge, ask about feeding, recovery, prescribed medicines, appointments, and whom to call about either parent or baby. Ask someone to demonstrate what you need to learn. Write down the answers while the people who can explain them are right there.

Share the work around the real needs

Feeding and recovery may shape what each person can do. Agree on what you’ll handle around them: supplies, settling, meals, laundry, transport, and messages. Arrange rest opportunities and a backup helper rather than assuming you’ll both just power through.

> **Set up safe sleep before you’re exhausted**
>
> Place baby on their back on a firm, flat, separate surface intended for infant sleep, with no soft bedding or toys. Avoid falling asleep with baby on a couch or armchair. Use current AAP guidance and ask your baby’s clinician about individual needs.

Fill out the First 72 Hours Plan. Then give yourselves permission to change it. You are making room for a new person, not proving you can run the old life perfectly.

VIV'S PERSPECTIVE

Evidence of life.

Viv | John's wife | A little chaos belongs in a home with people in it.



The little clothes on the chair. The cup I reheated and forgot again. The toys that somehow migrated across the room. I can love my family and still have a house that looks like people live there. Shocking, I know.

John and I have always had a saying: evidence of life. The goal is to leave room for the living while you look after the things that matter.

Here's where I put my energy

The care plan. A safe sleep space. Food, recovery, and the next appointment. I'm happy to let clean laundry spend a little time in the basket. Folding tiny pants is going to have to wait its turn.

Visitors can bring dinner

If you're coming over, come ready for a lived in house. Bring food. Offer to do the dishes. Let us tell you when we're ready for company. I'm giving myself permission to say, "Today doesn't work for us," without attaching a five paragraph apology. You and your partner get to do that too.

I want our energy going toward each other and the girls. A little chaos gets to be part of the picture. If the house is full of people we love, I'm leaving room for the evidence.

> **Your shared permission slip**
>
> Name one thing you can let be imperfect this week. Then name one thing you want to protect: a meal together, a few minutes outside, a quiet moment with your baby. Make room for that too.

AT HOME

When the plan meets real life.

Decide the next useful action rather than trying to win the whole week.

Both of you are exhausted

Say it early. Put baby in a safe sleep space before either adult risks falling asleep while holding them. Use the rest and backup plan. Call a trusted helper if available. Contact the care team if you are unsure how to meet feeding or care needs safely.

Feeding is not going as expected

Use the feeding instructions and contact information provided for your baby. Help with setup, supplies, and follow through. Seek guidance from the baby's clinician or appropriate feeding professional rather than treating a plan in a book as the answer for every baby.

Family wants a visit and you are not ready

Use the boundary you agreed on: "We are keeping today quiet. A meal drop off would help. We will let you know when we are ready for a visit." You can appreciate someone and still decline a visit.

You snap at each other

If everyone is safe, lower the temperature first. Name the specific mistake, apologize, and choose the next practical support. Return to the bigger conversation when you both have more capacity.

> **A concern about recovery or baby's health**
>
> Use the discharge instructions and call the appropriate care team promptly. If there is immediate danger, seek emergency help. Preparation should make it easier to get care, not become a reason to wait.

ABIGAIL'S CORNER

Make room for both of you.

Abigail Colander | Mike's wife | Licensed, Board Certified Behavior Analyst

After Riley arrived, a lot of people loved us at once. Family and friends were ready to meet the baby. Michael was the one who asked them to wait. He kept everyone updated, held the line kindly, and let them come in when I was ready and things at home felt steady. I didn't have to be the bad guy, and I didn't have to explain myself from a hospital bed.

That's a gift you can give your partner too. When everyone is tired, the plan should ask less of her memory and less of her energy.

Make the ask specific. "Can you bring dinner on Tuesday?" is easier to act on than "We should probably get some help." "Please handle the dishes before you leave" tells a willing visitor how to contribute. People aren't mind readers, even the people who love you.

Then look at who's doing the noticing. Is one person remembering everything and reminding everyone? Are both of you getting a chance to say what you need? Exhaustion won't make an unclear plan easier to follow, so adjust it together.

> **One useful check in**
>
> Ask: "What's making today harder than it needs to be?" Choose one small change to try. You can review it tomorrow.

My BCBA perspective here is about behavior, routines, and support. Bring medical, feeding, sleep, and mental health concerns to the appropriate care professional.

TOOL 09 OF 09

Your First 72 Hours Plan

Draft before birth. Update using the discharge instructions for your family.

NEED	OUR PLAN AND OWNER
Feeding support and care instructions	
Safe sleep space ready	
Rest opportunities for each adult	
Meals, water, and household basics	
Medication or recovery support as instructed	
Visitors and family updates	
Appointments and transport	
Backup if both of us need help	

Parent care contact and baby care contact

Questions we must ask before discharge

Our first review of this plan will be

DONE MEANS

Both of you know the immediate care plan, the next appointment, the contact numbers, and who can help. Rest arrangements fit feeding and recovery needs rather than a rigid timetable.

MAKE IT STICK

Seven days of useful progress.

Use this before birth. If time is short, do days one, five, and six first.

Day one · Find the open questions

Complete the Readiness Map. Pick three actions. Put a date beside them.

Day two · Build your support

Practice your reset. Contact the person on your Calm and Support Card and ask if they can be available.

Day three · Confirm the numbers

Review leave and income with your partner. Send the unanswered questions to the relevant employer, insurer, or adviser.

Day four · Own the work

Agree on household responsibilities. Take over one complete task without making your partner supervise the process.

Day five · Get ready for the room

Review the Birth Support Brief together. Confirm your care contacts, entrance, route, and bags.

Day six · Plan for home

Prepare the sleep space, meals, and help arrangements. Draft the First 72 Hours Plan.

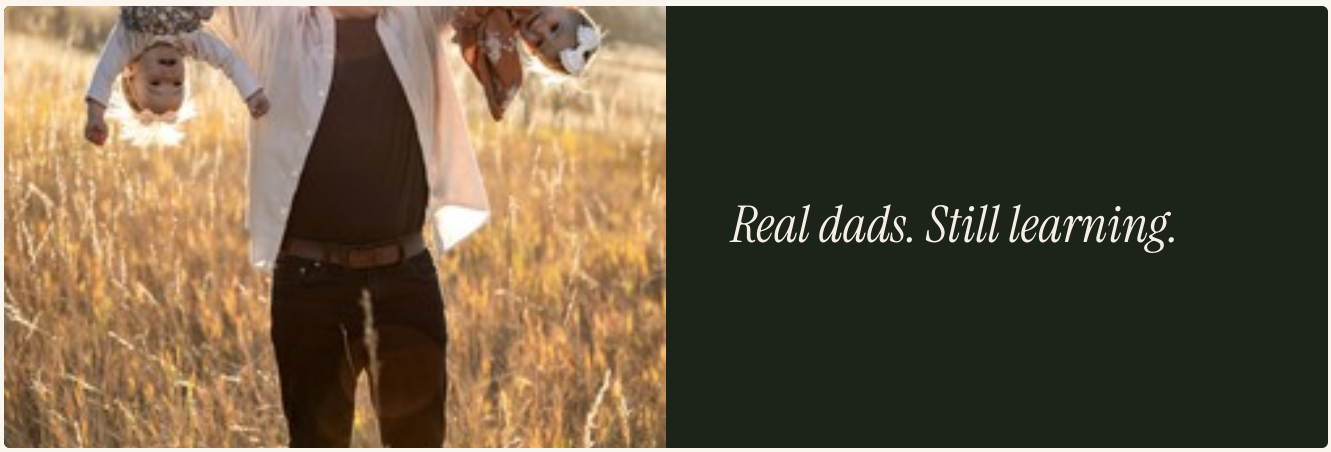
Day seven · Review together

Share your dad commitment. Ask what feels clearer and what still feels heavy. Update the plan and choose the next review date.

FROM THE FOUNDERS

Real dads. Still learning.

There's a whole life on the other side of getting ready.



John, Mike, Viv, Abigail, and the kids. That's the family behind these pages. The photos aren't there because we had it figured out. They're there because the life you're getting ready for happens in ordinary moments as well as the big ones.

You're going to learn things about yourself. Some will make you proud. Some will give you something to work on. Keep talking. Keep doing the small useful things. Let the people around you help.

> **Before you close the kit**
>
> Ask each other: "What feels clearer now? What still feels heavy? What's the next thing we'll do together?" You've already started the conversation that matters.

RESOURCES AND CARE

Keep the right help close.

These resources support preparation. They do not replace your family's care team.

Urgent maternal warning signs

CDC Hear Her explains warning signs during pregnancy and in the year after delivery. Changes in baby's usual movement, severe headache, trouble breathing, chest pain, and concerning bleeding are among the reasons to seek care immediately. Read the full resource; the examples here are not a complete checklist.

Read CDC urgent maternal warning signs →

cdc.gov/hearher/maternal-warning-signs

Safe infant sleep

The American Academy of Pediatrics explains safe sleep setup and the risks of couches, armchairs, soft bedding, and sharing a sleep surface. Discuss your baby's needs with their clinician.

Read the AAP guide to safe infant sleep →

healthychildren.org/English/ages-stages/baby/sleep/Pages/A-Parents-Guide-to-Safe-Sleep.aspx

Mental health and support

Ask your health professional about persistent anxiety, low mood, irritability, or difficulty functioning. Include support for both parents in your plan. If there is immediate danger or someone cannot stay safe, seek emergency help.

Before you put this kit away

Confirm that your care contacts are saved, your partner has a copy of the shared plan, and your next review is on the calendar.

> **Keep your information current**
>
> Reviewed against the linked public resources in October 2026. Care guidance can change. Follow current professional advice and the instructions provided for your family.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Bring your questions.

You've got a plan. You're allowed to want company too.



You've got a plan. You're allowed to want company too.

If these pages made you say, "Okay, but what about our situation?" that's a fair question. A worksheet can get a conversation started. Sometimes you want to keep it going with other dads and with us.

Come work through it live

The Dudela Workshop is a small group of 3 to 5 dads, live on Zoom with John and Mike. It meets the first Thursday of every month, 7:00 to 8:30pm Mountain. Bring the decisions you're working through and the questions you didn't know you had.

See the dates and save your seat →

thedudelaco.com/workshop

For today, use what you've got. Have the conversation. Pack the bag. Take one thing off her plate. You don't need to buy anything else to put this kit to work.

> **From our families to yours**
>
> You don't have to walk into this certain. You can walk in willing to learn, ready to take responsibility, and willing to ask for help. We're glad you're here. John & Mike